

Ornamentation of Paolo Veronese's Pictorial Space:

An Appraisal of *The Adoration of the Kings*

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When considering the late Italian Renaissance period, one should not ignore the Venetian artist Paolo Veronese, who created glorious work in his lifetime. Starting with the medium of fresco, he left his earliest work in Villa Barbaro: a series of wall paintings using the technique of *trompe l'oeil*. His precise control of actual and artificial spaces created a perfect balance between the real architectural surroundings and imaginary space in his artwork. Around half a decade later in 1573, the master transferred this practice from fixed media to canvas. With a focus on Veronese's prestigious altar piece, *The Adoration of the Kings* San Silvestro version (Fig. 1), the aim of this paper is to discuss the usage of ornamentation in Veronese's paintings from two major perspectives. First, the process that viewing experience shape the comprehension of the piece. Second, the way that the artist interact with audiences through the ornamentation, such as minor figure compositions and expression through the use of colour? Finally, I will consider the involvement of architectural elements and their iconic significance in supporting the religious narration.

First, I would like to define the concept of Veronese's ornamentation, used in this paper, as the minor objects. In short, these elements play less important roles in the narration but play a major part in establishing a stage, a background, or even the viewing experience, to assist in storytelling or merely for the purpose of being visually pleasing. Compared to the theatrical focus point, these marginal elements may appear dispensable; however, without their part in the picture's narration, one may miss a full enjoyment of the artwork. Therefore, using Veronese's San Silvestro *Adoration* as an example, I will

illustrate the significant role played by these minor elements in propelling pictorial expression, starting with the presentation of the artwork.

Location Change and Its Influence on Visual Experience

When approaching the San Silvestro version of *Adoration* in the National Gallery, London, one's eyes may be immediately drawn to the major activity happening in the frame. Mary is wearing her signature blue headdress while holding her baby, who is playfully waving his limbs in the air. The three kings, Caspar, Melchior and Balthasar—who have travelled afar from Tarsus, Arabia and Saba, respectively—are kneeling down with their gifts in an attitude of faithful respect.¹ Because of the artist's exquisitely designed composition, this momentous event instantly catches our attention. First, a total of eighteen human figures in the painting form the shape of an X, with Mary posed at the centre. To reinforce our attention, Veronese even puts an artificial spotlight on the Virgin and presents a sense of sacredness around her. Furthermore, Veronese guides audiences' attention in the way he portrays the gazes of his figures. In this painting, almost all the characters' eyes are pointing toward Mary. From the putti at the upper left to the kings in the foreground, their sights stop at the point where Mary is holding the baby Jesus and receiving the *Adoration* presentation. To further underline this significance, Veronese arranges two-thirds of figures in the bottom left, while the rest are situated in a V shape on the right of the frame, with Mary sitting at the bottom tip of the V. The barn, which

1. Xavier F. Salomon, *Veronese* (National Gallery Company Limited, 2014), 145.

functions as a frame, sets a boundary between the Virgin with the Christ and the other figures as well as separating the dominating actions from the supporting narratives.

Without the complex engagement of minor figures to form the geographical focus point, this massive piece might have appeared too broad to read.

Veronese believed in ‘the concept that a religious image should stimulate in the viewer “admiration and sympathy” (‘l’ammirazione e l’affetto’),² and this enormous painting utterly reflects his approach to religious artwork. Veronese finished the San Giuseppe *Adoration* in 1573. Though originally designed for altar presentation, it was placed on the left between two altars, in the church of San Silvestro in Venice³ We have no record of this change⁴, yet it provides a new visual perspective that arouses a sensation of crossing between fiction and reality. When walking towards the altar, one could approach the Virgin and the Christ from the same direction as the kings in the frame.⁵ Starting from the right-hand side, the first figure to catch the attention should be the king with the darker skin tone. He stands almost at the edge of the painting, and his right hand is not depicted in the frame. Even with his crown on, the king has travel-worn and dusty features. His green robe is flipped up to his shoulder, unveiling his midnight blue

2. Salomon, *Veronese*, 144.

3. Nicolas Penny, Ashok Roy and Marika Spring, ‘Veronese’s Paintings in the National Gallery Technique and Materials: Part II,’ *National Gallery Technical Bulletin* 17 (1996): 46.

4. None of the references in the bibliography has mentioned about the recorded reason for the San Silvestro Church selling this altar piece. Only Penny briefly notes in his essay that is painting might be sold because of the change of the taste. Nicolas Penny, 46.

5. Salomon, *Veronese*, 148.

undergarment. Clearly, he has just arrived; he is dismounting from his horse and is about to present his gift to the Christ. Moving towards the Christ is a series of kneeling figures. The loose-bodied burgundy cloak merely hints at the outline of the second king, yet it is sufficiently luxurious to signify his status without the presence of his crown. Two young pageboys kneel forward closely, followed by the king closest to Mary. The appearance of the boys between the kings visually breaks the tedious linear structure into a waving form that playfully guides our eyes towards Mary and Jesus.

Finally, we reach the king nearest Mary. With an open-armed gesture, the king's pose presents a mirror image of the baby Jesus's attitude. This echoing composition enhances the sense that the artist is inviting viewers to enter the space and share this moment. Therefore, walking in the same direction as the kings in the painting, one could feel the same sensation as those who have travelled from far away to offer their respect and gifts. Such a visceral experience may well have been felt by visitors to the San Giuseppe church. However, such an experience could only survive in the mind, because this painting was sold after being in the church for around 200 years.⁶

Now that it is displayed in the National Gallery, one has less opportunity to experience this sensation that corresponds to the Counter-Reformation's religious belief, unless one were to enter the gallery from somewhere other than the Sainsbury Wing. Nevertheless, the painting's new position in the National Gallery provides audiences with

6. Penny et al., 46.

a ‘retouring’ visual experience, which requires audiences firstly view from right to left in its geographical composition, then from left to right in the narration order. Thanks to Veronese’s geographical composition, the audience’s attention tends to be drawn to the lower right corner, where Mary, with her baby in the foreground where she receives visitors unobstructed, can be clearly seen. The viewer’s gaze then falls away from Mary, travelling from the golden-cloaked king to the last one in green and probably extending to the soldiers in the background. That would be the moment when viewers realise the intention of the artist’s continuity. By retouring back from the left to the right, one reaches the originally designated point of this visual experience. Starting from the king on the left, audiences could experience the journey of the Adoration by gently moving their sights from the king dismounting from his horse to the one taking off his crown and finally to the one presenting himself to Mary. Again, in this case, the kings not only represent themselves in the painting but also embody the audience’s will, taking them across the boundary of the frame and submitting themselves to the Christ and Mary.

Minor Figure Compositions

Around the same time, Veronese created a similar altar piece for the family chapel of the Santa Spina in the church of Santa Corona, Vicenza (Fig. 2). Scholars hold disparate opinions on the completion order of these two paintings. In her book *Paolo Veronese*, Alessandra Zamperini stated that the Vicenza version is Veronese’s first treatment of the adoration topic, while the San Giuseppe version appears to be the second

painting.⁷ However, Xavier F. Salomon asserted his belief that the Vicenza version came second, dating it to 1573–74⁸. It is indeed a difficult task to declare the accurate dates of these two paintings, especially when the artist was famous for his efficiency. We could probably use this question to view the San Silvestro *Adoration* from the perspective of the choice of composition and colours based on its public exhibited location.

In the San Silvestro version, Veronese presents a dramatic moment through the involvement of a number of minor figures. One of the most obvious features is the diversity of skin colour. The artist not only follows the literal story by depicting a darker-skinned king but also includes two pageboys with the same skin tone. One stands next to this king and the other kneels between the other two kings, serving as a conjunction point that smoothly transfers our gaze from the edge to the centre. The diversity of skin colours does indeed represent Christianity's extensive body of followers from a geographical perspective. To further push this dramatic moments in social terms, the artist positions twelve minor figures. Close behind the dark-skinned king are two soldiers in reflective armour on horseback. The artist again brings a sense of continuity by depicting two similar soldiers in the background, as if the two soldiers in the front are walking from that point. To further add layers of variety, Veronese introduces animals and people of lower classes into this sacred moment. A camel raises its head in the middle ground. The load of goods on its back appears to be quite a weight, and it seems to be struggling to maintain

7. Alessandra Zamperini, *Paolo Veronese* (Thames & Hudson), 182

8. Salomon, *Veronese*, 146.

its balance. The man next to it is waving a whip to prevent it from stumbling. This combination stands out because it brings a degree of exotic into the frame. Next to them, a man leaning against his white horse is looking down in the direction of Jesus. Along with the other male figure above him, who is kneeling on the ruins, the similar costumes of both figures create a sense of unity and indicate their social status—not poor but not wealthy, probably middle class. Moving our sights across the ruins, a man in tattered white garments is standing next to the barn. His relatively threadbare clothes appear worn out in some parts, as his right knee is revealed by the hole in his trousers. Another man with almost the same clothing—brown hat and white clothes—holds the leads of his dogs beneath him. Again, using their costumes as a clue, the artist sets this pair as a representation of people from the lower class. Together with the two pageboys kneeling in the foreground, these twelve minor figures lighten the painting with a mixture of geographical, social and generational diversity.

The Santa Corona piece, however, contains far fewer minor figures. Instead of depicting abundant supporting figures, Veronese chooses to focus on the reception of the kings and the representation of the holy family. The artist intentionally places Mary with her baby in the foreground, where she can be clearly seen receiving her guests unobstructed adoration. She sits against a half wall, two stairs up from the first kneeling king. Her rose-coloured dress reflects her pinkish cheeks, glowing under the touch of both the sunlight and a spotlight. Baby Jesus, with his little halo around his head, appears serene in the Virgin's arms, yet the artist still captures a child's inherent playfulness. The

depiction of his wandering feet adds a touch of frolicking naughtiness to this formal moment. Given that Veronese's daughter, Vittoria, was born in 1572, the playful infant Jesus might be a reflection of the new family member.⁹ Veronese tries his best to present the silkiness of Mary's cloak, as if the audience's gaze could slide from her rosy face to her shoulder to the corner covering her baby and then down to her bare right foot, where a king in yellow kneels down, so that both the magi and viewers prostrate themselves beneath Mary and Jesus.

Similarly to the San Silvestro version, two pageboys also closely follow this kneeling king, with one of them fixing his luxurious golden cloak. However, in this version, instead of a continuous line extending from the foreground to the background, the artist interrupts the series of kneeling figures by introducing a vertical gap in this horizontal composition. This allows us to take a break from considering this extravagant foreground—like that in the other version—and expand our vision to far away, witnessing the pilgrims still on the road. This composition provides a recess for the eyes, which take a detour from the foreground to the background and back, from far away to close by. Most importantly, it fits the presentation goal in the original location. Had Veronese chosen an identical format to the San Silvestro piece, the audiences may have needed to practice redirecting their eyes, as we must do today in the National Gallery.

To trace some of the history of the inspiration behind these two artworks,

9. Salomon, *Veronese*, 142.

Salomon illustrates that Veronese had once studied a woodcut print by Dürer of the same subject in his youth¹⁰ (Fig. 3). The similar arrangements, especially the figural compositions and architectural ornaments, indeed reflect the art historian's suggestion. Inspired by that northern artist, the figures in both of Veronese's paintings move horizontally from left to right. Mary, holding baby Jesus in her arms, sits on a higher position on the stairs, and standing behind her is Joseph. These depictions may be too identical to illustrate the choice of composition in conjunction with its exhibited space. However, Veronese created more than two versions under the theme of Adorations.

Prior to the two paintings mentioned above, in 1572, Veronese finished his first version of the *Adorations* as a commission for Ca' Ciccuna¹¹ (Fig. 4). Rather than depicting the mass of figures from left to right as in the two later versions, following the composition of Dürer's woodprint, Veronese developed the group from right to left. If we assume that Veronese drew his composition idea from Dürer's woodprint, then analysing the three versions of the *Adorations* may provide some rough clues to their order of completion.

In the 1572 version, Veronese depicted the Adoration event on an elongated canvas. The moderate background creates a contrast with its sophisticated foreground, where all the characters are concentrated. Again, Veronese's application of an artificial light illuminating Mary and the Christ from above ultimately draws the attention to this

10. Salomon, *Veronese*, 148.

11. Salomon, *Veronese*, 145.

most dramatic moment. Our eyes are then guided to the right, where the three kings in magnificent outfits are slightly larger in scale than the other figures. With his open-armed gesture, the nearest king to Mary reminds us of a similar figure in Titian's massive piece, *Portrait of the Vendramin Family*, especially because this painting is exhibited on the opposite wall from Veronese's San Silvestro version in the National Gallery (Fig. 5). In both Titian and Veronese's works, a male figure has one of his hands on his chest with the other extending in a welcoming motion that lessens the visual distance between the imaginary space and the reality. At this point, the application of foreshortening technique provides audiences with an illusion, as if the figure could invite the viewers across the boundary of the frame to join in this special moment. Furthermore, both figures reveal the inside lining of their luxurious cloaks, which have the same pattern: a slick fur with dots. Although these elaborate touches are visually pleasing, the composition of this initial version appears more chaotic than the later two. Indeed, the extended and elongated canvas, measuring 206 x 455 cm, requires more than the movement of one's eyes—viewers are required to move their entire bodies.¹² Therefore, the painting's size appears somewhat excessive on the medium of canvas, whereas a viewer could normally take in a painting's panorama at a glance. The action of voluntary displacement no longer only arouses a simultaneous sensation across the frame; it becomes more of a film-like

12. 'Veronese: The Cuccina Cycle. The Restored Masterpiece', Staatliche Kunstsammlungen Dresden, March 7, 2018, <https://www.skd.museum/en/besucherservice/press/2018/veronese-the-cuccina-cycle-the-restored-masterpiece/>.

experience due to the enormous size of this painting. More importantly, in a life-sized portrait such as this piece, an over-condensed arrangement of figures may disturb the continuity of the viewing experience. Rather than extend the painting using a distant imaginary space, Veronese compresses all the characters in the foreground. Minor figures mingle with the holy family and the kings, with less geographical composition and colour discrimination. The only way for audiences to identify major figures is by their slightly larger scales and luxurious outfits. In this version, one can sense Veronese's early approach to the topic of the Adoration; however, its elaborate depiction of ornamentation appears too heavy for its composition to support. Therefore, an adjustment is made in the two later versions.

The most obvious change appears in the arrangement of the canvas. Abandoning the scroll form, Veronese chooses a classical vertical presentation for the two altar pieces, one of which is on a perfectly rectangular canvas, while the other is drawn with an oblong top that serves to fit the dome of the family chapel. Nevertheless, one could view both paintings within one glance, and the development of foreground, middle ground and background enlarges the pictorial space to release our eyes from the interior to the exterior environment. Originally designed for public exhibition, the San Silvestro *Adoration* encompasses far more minor figures of various nationalities and social classes. As such, everyone who visited this public church could find a reflection of themselves in the painting. The Santa Corona version, however, was commissioned for another purpose. To create a relatively private sensation for the textile merchant Marcantonio Cogollo,

Veronese reduces his characteristic depiction of minor figures but draws full attention to the depiction of the holy family and the kings, who stand out for their location in the painting as well as the exquisite materials of their clothes. Additionally, the horse with the Cogollo family coat of arms further indicates that this painting was commissioned by a private patron to demonstrate his devotion to Christianity.

Colour

Veronese's choice of colours also alters the viewing experience and the expression of the artworks. Coming from a *terrafuma* practitioner to Venice, there is no doubt that Veronese had picked up Titian's characteristic use of colour. The rich pigments contrast with each other, creating a light-hearted tone that gives warmth to the composition. In both later versions of the *Adorations*, Veronese gradually prepares the stage from cool to warm tone. Moving from far to near, the light blue sky set a tranquil background and contrasts to the majestic events happening in the foreground. The two types of brown-toned architecture in the middle ground smoothly introduce the blue setting to the polychrome stage close to the audience. Instead of pure white, Veronese shades the classical ruins with a beige tone. This perfect transition smoothly shifts the colours from cool to warm. Moving forward, the brand-new barn warms the atmosphere into a fuscous tone, which prepares the stage for the iridescent hue and dramatic narration of the human figures. Through his masterful colour combination, Veronese builds an iridescent world with his pigments, and his San Silvestro *Adoration* best showcases this perspective.

Although Veronese created the Santa Corona altarpiece using an elaborate

composition, this version still appears insufficiently expressive for this glorious moment in the history of Christianity. The lack of minor figures directly reduces the colour repetition among the characters. In the San Silvestro *Adoration*, Veronese pays significant attention to details, such as setting people in groups who have similar colours. Continuing this trend of classifying figures by colour, the artist depicts the third king in a green robe and also gives the dark skin colour merchant a green outfit, because both figures represent pilgrims from distant lands.

As a major colour occupying almost half of the painting, the colour blue plays a significant role in the story's narration. This colour serves as a guide that leads audiences around the canvas with its diverse shades. This journey starts from the Virgin Mary's peacock-blue cloak to the flipped-up Persian blue inside lining of the nearest king's cloak, continuing to the furthest king's midnight-blue inner sleeves, to the blue sky at the very back, to the blue-green wings of the putti and back to the Virgin. This provides viewers with enough freedom to explore the painting without worrying about losing their way in this complex and theatrical event.

As Penny, Roy and Spring illustrate, azurite is the only blue pigment used in the painting.¹³ To present different shades of blue or to achieve other desirable colours, such as Balthasar's green coat, Veronese applies other pigments to azurite to form a new tone that adds shadow or lightens a spot in the painting. Another interesting fact about the

13. Penny et al., 48.

colour combination in the San Silvestro *Adoration* is the choice of colour for the kings' cloaks. In all three versions, Veronese shows a constant choice of colours for the two Caucasian kings, with the one nearest to Mary always covered with a golden cape while the following one is in red. However, none of the versions of Balthasar depict him in the same outfit, probably because his deep skin colour provides an additional identification that frees him from the limitations of clothing colour. In the initial version, Balthasar is dressed in a deep coloured robe with a light burgundy stripe, while in the Santa Corona piece, he is in deep blue.

Among them all, the most fascinating combination appears in the San Silvestro version. In 1572, Veronese finished another painting, entitled *The Cuccina Family Presented to the Virgin and Child with Saints John the Baptist and Jerome*, better known as *The Madonna of the Cuccina Family* (Fig. 6). This painting depicts a combination of a religious depiction with a family portraiture in which the holy family is positioned in a semi-exterior setting on the left of the frame while the figures of the patrons are located horizontally on the right. To further illustrate the nobility of this family, Veronese merges the virtues of faith, hope and charity in the white, green and red colours of the group.¹⁴ Adding additional hues of gold and blue, the tone of the San Silvestro *Adoration* happens to perfectly match the dress colour of the virtues. This fascinating echo among artworks reflects Veronese's extravagant expression in his masterful use of pigments.

14. Salomon, *Veronese*, 137.

Architecture

Amanda Lillie illustrates the significant role that architectural elements serve in a painting: ‘Architecture within pictures could be specifically designed to tell a visual story, articulating the plot, deepening viewers’ understanding of the moral or emotional content of the narrative, and helping them to engage imaginatively with the events’.¹⁵ In other words, such structural elements serve more than the purpose of aesthetic pleasure; they are also an iconographic intimation that corresponds to the pictorial theme. The architectural ornaments in Veronese’s *San Silvestro Adorations* are a good example.

Rather than presenting a formal ecclesiastic environment, Veronese chooses to narrate this religious story within a generic setting. In the middle ground, a newly built barn stands on ancient ruins. The thatch on the roof, which completely covers the classical structures, shines under the sunlight. The roughness and unadorned texture of the barn naturally sets a strong contrast with the aged stones that trace the passing of time, recalling audiences’ impressions of ancient Greek and Roman culture. Parallel with the barn, a sprout of a tree breaks from the old stone, growing right above the centre of the arch which features a decorative bull’s head. In ancient Roman culture, the bull represented Jupiter. Frequently, to portray their divine nature, Roman emperors were depicted with bull’s heads.¹⁶ Therefore, a ruined bull’s head with one broken horn has

15. Amanda Lillie, ‘Architectural Time’, last modified 2014, <http://www.nationalgallery.org.uk/paintings/research/exhibition-catalogues/building-the-picture/architectural-time/the-ruined-temple>.

16. Alexandra Koroxenidis, ‘The Bull in the Ancient World’, last modified April 21,

significant meaning: it represents the empire's decline from its political domination to its pagan-like religious beliefs. Meanwhile, the newly grown plant, as well as the under-construction barn, corresponds with the contemporary theme occurring in the frame – the orthodox belief has just arrived in this land. Growing from the obsolete base, though it is newly born, its potential appears inestimable.

Visual Attachments

Fig. 1. Paolo Veronese, *The Adoration of Kings*, 1573, oil on canvas, National Gallery, London



Fig. 2. Paolo Veronese, *The Adoration of Kings*, 1573–74? Oil on canvas, Church of

Santa Corona, Vicenza



Fig. 3. Albrecht Dürer, *The Adoration of the Magi*, 1501–02, woodcut, Museum of New Zealand Te Papa Tongarewa, Wellington



Fig. 4. Paolo Veronese, *Die Anbetung der Könige* (*The Adoration of Kings*), 1571–72, oil on canvas, Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister, Dresden



Fig. 5. Titian, *Portrait of the Vendramin Family*, 1540–45, oil on canvas, National Gallery, London



Fig. 6. Paolo Veronese, *The Madonna of the Cuccina Family*, 1571–72, oil on canvas, Gemäldegalerie Alte Meister, Dresden

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